

Team Name

AI Explorers

Team Mission / Purpose

Our team's purpose is to design and prototype a generative AI-driven customer experience that better understands individuals and enhances how they discover financial products. Rather than relying on traditional transactional recommendations, we aim to explore new ways of identifying semantic relationships between users' goals, behaviors, and life stages to create a more personalized and intuitive onboarding experience. The opportunity lies in aligning financial products with where customers are in their life cycle, helping them feel understood rather than filtered into generic categories. By the end of the semester, our goal is to deliver a functional prototype and supporting insights that demonstrate how a more human-centered, context-aware approach can improve user experience, strengthen engagement, and provide meaningful value to Synchrony Financial.

Customer / Business Group Description

The customer business group requesting this work wants the team to explore generative AI applications for product discovery and identify opportunities for innovation. This group is responsible for designing and evolving customer-facing digital experiences that help consumers understand, select, and engage with Synchrony's financial products across different life stages and use cases.

The key customers for the team's outputs include product managers, UX designers, data/AI strategy teams, and digital transformation leaders within Synchrony. These stakeholders will use the team's deliverables, user research insights, personas, UI/UX prototypes, and a functional demo, to inform future product discovery strategies, evaluate the feasibility and value of generative AI-driven personalization, and guide internal discussions around human-centered financial experiences. The outputs are intended to serve both as a conceptual proof of value and a practical design reference that can be leveraged in future pilots, roadmap planning, and cross-functional alignment efforts within the organization.

Project Motivation

Synchrony requested this project to investigate alternative, AI-enabled approaches to understanding customer preferences and decision drivers beyond traditional market basket analysis. While existing methods are effective at identifying what products are purchased together, they provide limited insight into why customers make those choices or how preferences evolve over time. The sponsor is interested in exploring more personalized, context-aware frameworks that can better map customer attributes, behaviors, and intent to financial product discovery and engagement. This work is particularly relevant as Synchrony seeks to design more human-centered, insight-driven financial experiences that move past purely transactional models and toward solutions that feel adaptive, explainable, and strategically actionable.

Expected Accomplishments

Week 1-4 | Research phase: During the research phase we are expected to dig deeper into the problem to formulate a creative solution to address the problem. The steps and objectives to do so will look at our

target user along with addressing other factors such as the services Synthiony has to offer and how different services can be tailored to the users.

- 1) Create 4-5 personas of potential users and the respective pain points and how this product would attempt to resolve it
- 2) Understand all of Synchrony's offerings to its customers and the consumers being those products.
- 3) Research exists solutions and other alternatives in the market and their pros and cons.

Week 5-9 | Prototype phase: During the prototype phase we look to start to brainstorm ideas and develop multiple simple prototypes to visually demonstrate our ideas. Through this project we will work closely with the client to determine features that we should include or ignore. At the end of this phase we hope to have a single idea that we can further develop into a more in-depth product that can be demoed.

- 1) Create 4-5 UI mock up prototypes of ideas in Figma with reasoning behind the decision made for each idea.
- 2) Meet with the client to iterate on the ideas and get feedback.
- 3) Pick one of the refined ideas to further develop.

Week 10-16 | Demo phase: During the demo phase we look to build the core functionality behind the product that we picked for the client. We will continue to work closely with the client to make sure the product aligns with their vision during this time. In the end we wish to show the demo to the client and provide a detailed report of our findings.

- 1) Develop the backend and frontend of the product further than the mock up prototype.
- 2) Report findings and assumptions in report and demo product to client.

Guiding Principles - Pranav

- Maintain mutual respect and professionalism in all interactions, valuing diverse perspectives and contributions from every team member
- Respect everyone's time by being punctual, prepared, and mindful of meeting efficiency and workload distribution
- Communicate clearly, proactively, and in a timely manner, raising questions or concerns early to avoid misalignment
- Foster an open and collaborative environment where ideas can be challenged constructively and feedback is welcomed
- Use an agreed-upon decision-making process, prioritizing consensus when feasible and defaulting to majority vote when necessary
- Take ownership and accountability for assigned tasks, delivering work that meets agreed-upon standards and deadlines
- Support one another during high-intensity phases of the project and maintain shared responsibility for overall team success

Time Commitments

Outline agreed-upon meeting times outside of class, advisor meeting cadence, expected weekly time commitment per team member, and expectations during peak project phases.

Weekly Check-in: Thursdays 3:30 - 4:30 PM CST

- 3:30 - 4:00 : Group meeting w/ advisor
- 4:00 - 4:30 : Meeting with Gabe (Synchrony advisor)

Meeting outside of class:

- Tuesday 3:30 - 4:00 PM CST (In-person)
- Thursday 4:30 - 5:00 PM CST (Virtual)

These times are subject to change depending on the deliverables due for that week. We are expected to meet for around 1-2 hours per week. Additionally, we will each be assigned individual work for the week that would take anywhere from 2-6 hours per week to do. During peak project phases, especially closer to the deadline we expect the work for each individual to hover around 10 hours per week.

Team and Contact Information

Eshana Jain
+1 447-902-7972
eshanaj2@illinois.edu

Satyam Singh
+1 224-258-3891
satyams2@illinois.edu

Tarika Oberai
+1 630-842-6221
toberai2@illinois.edu

John Maas
+1 708-518-1878
jhmaas2@illinois.edu

Pranav Penmatcha
+1 847-890-8022
pcp3@illinois.edu

Professor Vishal Sachdev
vishal@illinois.edu
+1 217 244 2420

Gabriel Ortiz (Synchrony Point of Contact)
gabriel.ortiz@syf.com